AMS - News Articles

Layad nen Sikhafan: Cordillera's Most Popular Song

By: Anatalia M. Saboy

Contemporary researches on Cordillera musicology reveal that even before the Spanish colonizers set foot on Philippine sail, the aboriginal inhabitants of what is now known as the Cordillera Region had their own pristine culture, alive with native songs and dances. However, it was only during the early years of American Occupation of the Philippines that Cordillera songs found their way to the written documents now available to students of musicology.

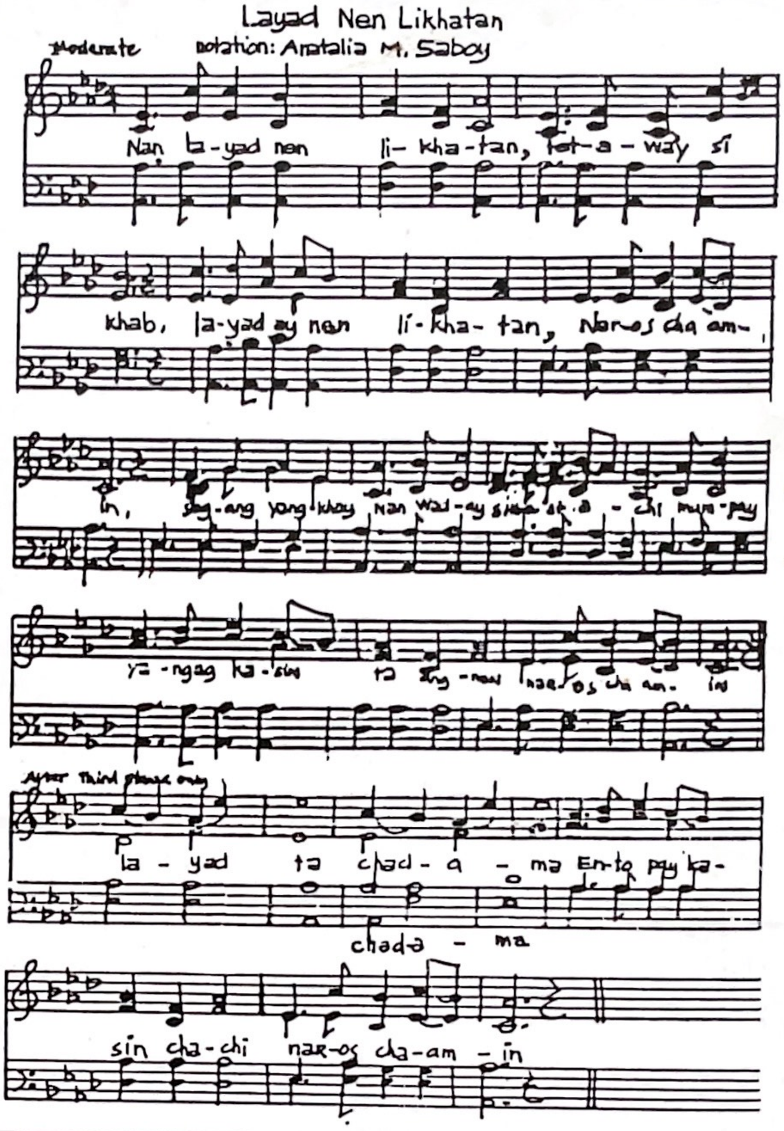
Among the earliest documentary studies on Cordillera music was conducted by an American couple, Mr. and Mrs. Fay Cooper Cole who recorded Tingguian songs which were later examined, analyzed and notated by Albert Gale, an American musicologist of the University of Chicago. Subsequently, an educator, the late Alfredo Pacyaya of Sagada, and an American Anthropologist, Fred Eggan, made spe recording of Sagada songs which were also notated for prosterity.

Later, researches were undertaken by American and Filipino educators on the different Cordillera songs which found also their inclusion in the early textbooks on Philippine music. A number of these songs were notated and are found in the Progressive Music Series textbooks in Philippine grade and intermediate schools up to the Commonwealth Period of the Republic.

Not all of these Cordillera songs in these textbooks found their way to the hearts of Filipinos because with Western Culture spreading fast throughout the country, love and pride in the country's indigenous songs were relegated into the background in favor of American or Western music. The renaissance of indigenous Filipino music came after the Philippines was granted its political independence on July 4, 1964. The nationalization of the country's educational curriculum helped rekindle the Filipino's pride in their culture and Filipino indigenous songs began to dominate the songs sang and taught in the schools.

Yet, it must also be admitted that the songs brought in by our western colonizers have influenced Cordillera Ethnic songs with their melody impregnations, resulting in the mutations of songs and music sang by our present-day Cordillera bards and warblers. An example of this is the sibg "Nan Layad Nen Sikhafan" – facetiously known as the "Bontoc Cordillera Hymn" for having originated and widely sang in Bontoc.

Among the most popular Cordillera songs today, "Nan Layad Nen Sikhafan", curiously, is a native song with a foreign melody. In 1976, while this writer was teaching in the Mt. Province Comprehensive High School, she stumbled upon a song in an American Hymnal whose melody was strikingly similar to that of the melody of the popular Bontoc song "Nan Layad Nen Sikhafan". This song in the hymnal was captioned "There is Beauty All Around" with music attributed to J.H. McNaughton (1863) notated in four voices.


Layad Nen Likhatan
Moderate
notation: Anatalia M. Saboy
Nan la-yad nen li- kha-tan, fet-a-way si
khab, la-yad ay nan li-kha-tan, Nar-os cha am-
in, sag-ang yong-khay nan wal-ay - chi mam-pay
ya-ngag ka-sin ta sing-nen nar-os cha am- in
After third stanza only
la - yad ta chad - a - ma En-to pay ka-
chada - ma
sin cha-chi nar-os cha-am - in

2. San enta nen fowekhan
Ad-im ngen semken
San enta nen pachangan
Nar-os cha am-in
Sik-a et achi mampay
Em e-gay sin-sinmek na
Sampay taynan si Ama
Nar-os cha am-in.

3. Tak-en ma nimawasa
Sumeg-ang ka man
Ta kasin ta lebnayen
San layad fa'y chuea
San layad ta'y chad-ama
Wed-wedcha's fangonenta
Ta't mampay men-among ta
Omafong ta'y chuwa

(Sang only as a refrain after the third stanza)

Layad ta, chad-ama
Ento pay kasin cha-chi
Nar-os cha am-in.

With some modifications in the composition to suit the lyrics and slurs of the Bontoc version, she taught the four-voiced song to her school choir which she had organized. For the first time. "Layad Nen Sikhafan" was sung in four voices to the delight of the Bontoc folk.

"Layad Nen Sikhafan" is an accomplished love song. This is the reason why it is intimately and heartily sang by people of different ages – rom the grade school children to the ageing parents fading into the twilight of their lives. The lyricist is not know but its authorship is generally credited to the late Timothy D. Chaokas, a native Bontoc educator who rose to become one of the colorful political leaders of the old Mountain Province, serving as Provincial Secretary and later as Vice Governor of the old Mountain Province.

The song was popularized by a Bontoc singer, Pedro Chinalpan who had it recorded in phonograph discs in the 1960s while working as a bus driver of the Dangwa Transportation Company. Since then, many parodies were produced by enterprising Cordillera Singers. Some of the guerilla songs of the New People's Army (NPA) and Cordillera People's Liberation Army (CPLA), which were composed to suit their morale-boosting songs, were sang to the tune of "Layad Nen Sikhafa".

The full composition of the "Layad Nen Sikhafan" in quadruple voice is reproduced with this article for the benefit and convinience of music classes and for youth and adult choirs who would like to teach the song in four voices. Four college brass hands, the composition would come in handy for parade and review music (may be portion of the parade and review) of ROTC and PMA cadet units.

It is to be stressed, at this juncture, that the melody of "Layad Nen Sikhafan" is not, indigenously Cordillera. But like other ethnic songs sang in the region, this popular Bontoc ethnic song has given additional color and historicity to the ecclectic culture that the Philippines today owns as a result of years of acculturation.

CORDILLERA ETHNIC SONGS AND DANCES

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MADAM MODERATOR, Friends, Ladies and Gentlemen;

My assignment this afternoon is to talk on the Cordillera ethnic songs and dances. Actually, this subject should have been given to two individuals --- one to discourse on Ethnic Songs and the other on Ethnic Dances. These are two broad subjects which need special treatment and detailed exposition. As you may have already known, we have in the Cordillera region scholars and researchers who made studies on the ethnic dances of the different ethnic groups of the Cordilleras. We have, for instance, Dr. Remigio Monroe of the Benguet State University and Dr. Josephine Flores of the DECS-CAR Regional Office who had conducted researches and studies on ethnic dances of this highland country. And, some others which work on this subject have enriched the knowledge about these ethnic dances.

Although my specialization is in Music and Songs of Cordillerans which were the subjects of my masteral thesis and doctoral dissertation, I will try to cover both topics assigned to me within the thirty-minute period alloted to me.

Cordillera Eth

The Americans are credited for the establishment and structuring of the Philippine public schools system under the Philippine Commission at the start of the century. It was along their search for curricular materials for the new schools program that American educators had stumbled on a trasure cove of Cordillera ethnic songs which they did not hesitate to include in the repertoire of Philippine ethnic songs, some of which found their way to the music textbooks adopted for use in the elementary and secondary schools. The music books like the Philippine Progressive Music Series and Philippine Music Horizons were the standard music textbooks where some Cordillera ethnic songs were incorporated.

There were Tinggian (Abra), Benguet, Bontoc, Kalinga, Apayao and Ifugao ethnic songs which were included in these text books, translated into English. Some examples which may be given here [illegible]" [illegible] origin; "Bagbagtu", a Benguet folk song; "Wild Pigeon", "Pounding Song" (Kalinga); "Bird and the Pipe" (Diwdiw-as) from Abra and "Pound Rice for Dinner" (Pagpag) of Bontoc origin, and similar ones which are popularly sung by school children during the pre-war and postwar years.

The post war years saw the resurgence if researches on Cordillera music undertaken by leading Filipino musicologists like Jose Maceda, who, together with Alfredo Pacyaya, an Igorot educator and Fred Eggan, an American anthropoligist studied Sagada songs. About the earliest researcher on highland music whose works had preseded those of the studies made by Maceda was Fay Cooper Cole, an American anthroplogist from the University of Chicago who recorded and later notated Tinggian ethnic songs of Abra. Among Cole's work inlcuded the Dawak, Ballagoyos, and Daeng. Then, too, Belgina missionaries like Francisco Billiet and Francis Lambrecht did some invaluable studies on Southern Kalinga music and also Ifugao music.

The researches of these scholars paved the way for the bumper harvest of Cordillera ethnic songs researchers during the post-martial law years. Many of these researchers have documented in unpublished theses and disserations the different indigenous songs of the Cordilleras. Among these are, Rosita Brillantes and Candido Wail of Abra; who studied contemporary Tinggian ethnic songs; Norma Malateo, Evangeline Gewan and Elsie Padeo on Western Mountain Province (Igorot) music; Edward Moltio, June Tabdi, Vicenta Sabaoan and Restituto Bangaoil on Benguet songs; Juanita Madarang on Ifugao songs; and Demetria Manuel and Felicidad Prudente on Apayao (Isnag) songs. I had made studies on Western Kalinga music (Banao) but there is much area to cover for researches on the Northern and Southern Kalinga music and songs all of which are open for research.

The general characteristics of the Cordillera ethnic songs are: On melody, most of the scales are pentatonic. Some are two-tone, three -tone to four -tone. Majority of syllables per line is seven. Some are six and eight syllables. There are about four to eight verses per stanza. For melodic contour, the songs move in primes, seconds and thirds, although there are exceptions suc as the Ullalims and Ading of the Kalingas which go as high to the 8th note and above. In rhythm, most songs are moderate, usually in 2/4 and 3/4 time signature. In the ballads and other ethnic songs, they are non-metric. For harmony, they are monophonic and sung acapella. In songs for the wake of the dead, for mass-wedding festivals and peace pacts or during courtship, they sing them in a leader-group-debate or responsorial style where a leader starts a few syllables and the others simulaneously follow. in his group. Then a leader on the other side also starts to answer and his group simulaneously follow. This debate continues until they are tired. The theme will depend on what occasion. The text style is usually syllabic-neumatic. But for some like the *Oggayam*, *Ullalim* and *sogsogna*, these have plenty of mellismatic settings where there are many notes to a syllable. The form for the majority is stroophic. Cordillera songs are mostly sang in unison.

Ethnic Dances

The different ethnic dances of the Cordilleras are associated with rituals and ceremonies like the *Tayao*, *Bendian*, and *Palis* of Benguet. So also with the *Takik*, *Balangbang*, and *pinanyoan* of Sagada and Besao, or the Mangangsa of Northeastern Bontoc; the *pallo-ok* or *pattong* and and tadokand *tuppaya* of the Kalinggas; the bangibang and pinykla of the Ifugaos and last but not the least the *Taddok* of the Isnags of Kalinga-Apayao.

According to Remigio Monroe who made extensive studies on Cordillera dances, these dances are performed for the following reasons: to mark the milestone in the life cycle of the natives such as birth, marriage and death; to cure ailments believed to have been caused by offended ancestral spirits; to thank *Kabonian* and the ancestral spirits for a bountiful harvest; and to supplicate both good and evil spirits regarding health, misfortune and sickness.

The common dance steps and movements of the Cordillera dances are performed in a circle formation in an open area on the grounds; the stumping, shuffling, running, hopping, raising of the foot above the ground and raising of knees are the common steps. The common movements are the bending of the body, spreading of arms in lateral position, fingers clipped together with open palms or closed fists.

The meaning and significance attached to these dancessteps and and movements are also identical: the spreading of arms in a lateral position like the wings of their sacred bird, the *idaw* (i-chew in Bontoc) signifies their love of freedom and liberty; the placing of hands on hips or waist signifies confidence and pride; fingers that are clipped together signifies their unity and solidarity; palms facing outward or upward signify a characteristic of prayer, a constant relationship with their different supernatural spirits whom they supplicate and invoke in times of misfortune and illness.

The brass gongs are commonly found among these ethnic groups of the Cordilleras. They come in different sizes ranging from 25 to 45 centimeters in diameter. They are called *gansa* or gangha (Ifugao). The rim are from 4-1/2 to 6-1/2 centimenters in height. A cord is tied to the eyelettes bored in pairs and attached to the handle. Some handles are of board tusks or artfully designed wood carved U-shaped. Some gansas are also fitted with human jawbone handles. The jaw bones are taken from persons killed in tribal wars taken as part of the war booties. The handle facilitates the grip held with the left hand.

The size of the gong gives its pitch. The large the size, the lower the pitch when struck with a stick fitted on its end with cloth. For some dances, the palm is used to play the gong either with one or with two palms to produce the desired staccato music. The Isnags, Tinguians and the Western and northern Kalingas use both palms of the hand in the playing the gong in a row of five to six players, kneeling. All of the skillful beatings produce the music to which the dancers skip and run dancing in cifcules.

Another indispensable partner of the gong is the drum. The (Ibalois) Benguets and the Kankanais of Benguet and Mt. Province have the solibao, an elongated hollowed wood with its open end covered with animal hide. This solibao is an indispensable accompaniment of the brass gongs played by the team of players. In Apayao, the Isnegs have their own "solibao" which they call ludag The Tingians have also their own type of drums which is alike the modern bass drums with two ends of the hollowed wood covered with animal hide and which when heated produces a sonorous boom-boom.

Based on the observation and studies on these ethnic dances, no definite number of steps for the dancers are done while performing. There are no fixed patterns to follow and the dancer usually creates or innovates his/her steps as well as the patterns of movements as it is performed to the tune of the brass gong music. The dancer with his own gusto also does not limit the time of performance but they dance and dance as they enjoy until they tire out or until the players of the gons also drops out for fatigue.

For instructional purposes, however, researches have already been conducted to measure the steps of dances. The scientific measurements enables teachers to teach effectively and artfully as well as time-frame the duration of the dancing. Dir Joephine Flores with the aid of 82 participants from the different ethnic groups in the Gordillera region had documented some ethnic dances towards the numbering of steps and also the setting down of patterns during a seminar-workshop held in Baguio City.

Such a step towards the scientific recording and documenting of the ethnic dances would immensely help in the effective teaching of the dances in our schools. Dean Macario Fronda of the St. Louis University, together with other musicologists in the Cordilleras have collaborated to ome out with a an instructional materials that would record the steps, dance patterns, fugures and formations, rhythmic patterns and directions. While these are modifying actually the indigenous dance steps and patterns, these researches will be contributing immensely to the preservation of our cultural treasures especially those from the Cordillera region.

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